三十分钟

一个外卖骑手的雨天

Thirty Minutes

A rainy day in the life of a delivery rider

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 在这座城市里，一碗面从厨房到饭桌上，大约需要三十分钟。这三十分钟里，有饭店做饭的十分钟，有路上的十五分钟，还有等电梯、爬楼梯、找门牌的五分钟。等饭的人在手机上看到的，只是地图上一个慢慢移动的小点。周海[†]就是这样一个小点。他三十四岁，来自湖南[‡]的一个小山村，在深圳[§]送外卖已经是第四年了。

早上六点

2 早上六点，闹钟还没响，周海就醒了。雨打在铁皮房顶上，噼里啪啦[¶]地响，像有人在上面打鼓。这是城中村[*]里的一间出租屋，不到十五平方米，放着两张上下铺，住着四个男人。周海睡上铺，一抬头就能碰到天花板。他摸出手机看了看天气：暴雨预警，一整天都有雨。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 湖南 *Húnán* Hunan province
§ 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
¶ 噼里啪啦 *pīlipālā* pitter-patter
* 城中村 *chéngzhōngcūn* urban village

In this city, it takes about thirty minutes for a bowl of noodles to travel from a kitchen to a dining table. Those thirty minutes hold ten minutes of cooking at the restaurant, fifteen minutes on the road, and five more of waiting for lifts, climbing stairs and searching for door numbers. All the person waiting for the food sees on their phone is a little dot creeping across a map. Zhou Hai was one of those little dots. He was thirty-four, from a small mountain village in Hunan, and this was his fourth year delivering takeaway food in Shenzhen. 1

Six in the Morning

At six in the morning, before the alarm had even gone off, Zhou Hai was awake. Rain was drumming on the sheet-iron roof, as if someone up there were beating a drum. It was a rented room in an urban village, less than fifteen square metres, with two bunk beds and four men living in it. Zhou Hai slept on a top bunk; if he lifted his head, he bumped the ceiling. He fished out his phone and checked the weather: a rainstorm warning, rain all day. 2

3 下雨天对骑手[†]来说，有好处，也有坏处。好的是，不愿意出门的人多了，单子也就多了，每单还有一两块钱的补贴。坏的是，路滑，眼前一片白，车也开得急，很容易出事。下铺的老马[‡]已经起来了，正蹲在门口用热水泡方便面。他五十多岁，河南[§]人，在这一行干了七年，是这间屋子里跑得最久的。

4 “今天暴雨，你还跑啊？”老马头也不抬地问。“跑。下雨天单子多。”“钱是挣不完的。”老马说，“你小心点儿，别跟那个钟比赛。”周海[¶]笑了笑：“放心，我就是多跑几单罢了，又不是去拼命[*]。”老马没说话，只是看了他一眼。那一眼，周海后来想起过很多次。

5 周海的手机屏幕上，是女儿小禾[#]的照片。

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† 骑手 *qíshǒu* rider
‡ 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Old Ma
§ 河南 *Hénán* Henan province
¶ 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
* 拼命 *pīnmìng* to risk one's life
\# 小禾 *Xiǎohé* Xiaohe, Zhou Hai's daughter

For a rider, a rainy day is good news and bad news. The good part is that more people don't want to go out, so there are more orders, and each one comes with an extra yuan or two. The bad part is that the roads are slippery, everything in front of you is a white blur, the cars drive impatiently, and it is easy to have an accident. Old Ma from the bottom bunk was already up, squatting by the door and pouring hot water over a cup of instant noodles. He was in his fifties, from Henan, and had been in the job for seven years, longer than anyone else in the room. 3

"There's a rainstorm today. You're still going out?" Old Ma asked without looking up. "I am. There are more orders when it rains." "There's always more money to earn," said Old Ma. "Be careful. Don't race against that clock." Zhou Hai smiled. "Don't worry. I'm just doing a few more orders, that's all. It's not like I'm going to risk my neck." Old Ma said nothing; he just gave him a look. Zhou Hai would think of that look many times afterwards. 4

On Zhou Hai's phone screen was a photo of his daughter, Xiaohe. 5

5 小禾[1]八岁，跟奶奶住在湖南[2]老家，他一年只回去一次。昨天晚上视频的时候，女儿问他："爸爸，深圳[3]下雨吗？你送外卖会不会淋[4]湿？"他说："爸爸有雨衣，一点儿也不湿。"他心里有一个计划：再干两年，存够钱，就回县城开一家小饭馆，做他妈妈的辣椒炒肉[5]。那样，他就能每天送女儿上学了。

6 他把手机装进一个透明的塑料袋，免得屏幕被雨打湿了不好用。然后穿上雨衣，戴上头盔[6]，下了楼。他本来打算六点半就开始接单，不料电动车的电池只剩下百分之十，他只好冒着雨先去换电站[7]换电池。等他打开软件，按下"开始接单"，已经快七点了。

1 小禾 *Xiǎohé* Xiaohe, Zhou Hai's daughter
2 湖南 *Húnán* Hunan province
3 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
4 淋 *lín* to get soaked
5 辣椒炒肉 *làjiāo chǎoròu* chilli-fried pork (Hunan dish)
6 头盔 *tóukuī* helmet
7 换电站 *huàndiànzhàn* battery-swap station

Xiaohe was eight and lived with her grandmother back home in Hunan; he went back only once a year. On their video call the night before, his daughter had asked him, "Dad, does it rain in Shenzhen? Do you get wet when you deliver food?" He had said, "Dad has a raincoat. I don't get wet at all." He had a plan in his head: two more years, save enough money, then go back to the county town and open a little restaurant serving his mother's chilli-fried pork. Then he could take his daughter to school every day. 5

He slipped his phone into a clear plastic bag, so that the rain wouldn't soak the screen and make it hard to use. Then he put on his raincoat and his helmet and went downstairs. He had meant to start taking orders at half past six, but to his dismay the scooter's battery was down to ten per cent, so he had to go out in the rain to a battery-swap station first. By the time he opened the app and pressed "Start taking orders," it was almost seven. 6

第一单

七点零二分，手机“叮”[1]的一声，第一单来了。两份肠粉[2]，一杯热豆浆[3]，从一家早餐店送到三公里外的一座写字楼。屏幕上写着：预计送达时间七点三十二分。三十分钟。旁边还有一个小小的数字，一秒一秒地往下减。

周海[4]刚来深圳[5]的时候，同样远的路，系统给他四十分钟。后来变成了三十五分钟，现在是三十分钟。老马[6]跟他解释过：系统会记住每个骑手[7]每一次用了多少时间。大家越跑越快，系统就认为这条路本来只需要这么久，下一次给的时间就更少了。“所以啊，”老马说，“我们每天都在跟昨天的自己比赛。”

1 叮 *dīng* ding (sound)
2 肠粉 *chángfěn* rice noodle rolls
3 豆浆 *dòujiāng* soy milk
4 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
5 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
6 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Old Ma
7 骑手 *qíshǒu* rider

The First Order

At two minutes past seven, the phone went "ding": the first order had arrived. Two portions of rice-noodle rolls and a cup of hot soy milk, from a breakfast shop to an office building three kilometres away. The screen read: estimated delivery time 7:32. Thirty minutes. Next to it was a tiny number, counting down second by second. 7

When Zhou Hai first came to Shenzhen, the system gave him forty minutes for a trip that long. Later it became thirty-five minutes, and now it was thirty. Old Ma had explained it to him once: the system remembers how long every rider takes on every trip. The faster everyone rides, the more the system believes the trip only ever needed that long, and the next time it gives even less. "So you see," Old Ma had said, "every day we're racing against ourselves from yesterday." 8

9 早餐店的老板娘手很快，可是下雨天叫外卖的人太多，门口站了一排穿雨衣的骑手[†]。周海[‡]等了八分钟，才拿到那个热乎乎的袋子[§]。他把豆浆放进保温箱[¶]，跨上车就走。早高峰的路上全是车，雨水顺着头盔[*]流进衣服里，冰凉冰凉的。他在车和车之间慢慢往前挤，眼睛不时看一眼手机上的数字。

10 写字楼的保安不让骑手坐客梯，他只好绕到后面去等货梯。七点三十分，他敲开了十八楼一间办公室的门。开门的是一个年轻男人，头发乱乱的，眼睛红红的，像是一夜没睡。他接过袋子，眼睛还看着自己的手机，说了声“谢谢”，门就关上了。从开门到关门，不过两秒罢了。周海看了看屏幕：“已送达”，没有超时。他长长地吐了一口气。

† 骑手 *qíshǒu* rider
‡ 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
§ 豆浆 *dòujiāng* soy milk
¶ 保温箱 *bǎowēnxiāng* insulated delivery box
* 头盔 *tóukuī* helmet

The woman who ran the breakfast shop worked fast, but on a rainy day too many people order in, and a row of riders in raincoats stood at her door. Zhou Hai waited eight minutes before he got the warm bag. He put the soy milk into his insulated box, swung onto the scooter and went. The morning rush-hour roads were packed with cars, and rainwater ran down from his helmet into his collar, ice cold. He squeezed slowly forward between the cars, glancing every now and then at the number on his phone. 9

The building's security guard didn't let riders use the passenger lifts, so he had to go round the back and wait for the freight lift. At half past seven he knocked at an office door on the eighteenth floor. The man who opened it was young, his hair a mess and his eyes red, as if he had not slept all night. He took the bag with his eyes still on his own phone, said "thanks," and the door closed. From the door opening to the door closing took no more than two seconds. Zhou Hai looked at the screen: "Delivered." Not late. He let out a long breath. 10

11 等货梯下楼的时候，他想起了一个地址：阳光花园 7 号楼1202。这半年来，他往那里送过十几次，都是晚上十点以后，点的都是最便宜的套餐。订单†的备注永远是同一句话：“麻烦快一点，谢谢！放门口就行。”他一次也没见过这位顾客，只知道是个女的。每次看到那句“快一点”，他心里都想：城里人，就是性子急。

雨

12 十一点以后，雨越下越大。天黑得像傍晚一样，路边的树被风吹得东倒西歪‡。午饭时间是一天里最忙的时候。哪怕雨下得再大，人总是要吃午饭的；而越是下雨，越没人愿意下楼。周海§的手机几乎没有停过，系统一下子给他派了四单：三份盒饭，一份汤，四个地址分别在四个方向。

† 订单 *dìngdān* order (online)

‡ 东倒西歪 *dōngdǎo xīwāi* to sway every which way

§ 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai

Waiting for the freight lift to go down, he thought of an address: Sunshine 11
Gardens, Building 7, Flat 1202. In the past six months he had delivered there a dozen-odd times, always after ten at night, and always the cheapest set meal. The note on the order was always the same: "Please hurry, thank you! Just leave it at the door." He had never once seen this customer; he only knew it was a woman. Every time he saw that "please hurry," he thought: city people, always impatient.

Rain

After eleven, the rain grew heavier and heavier. The sky was as dark as 12
dusk, and the trees by the road were blown every which way. Lunchtime is the busiest part of the day. However hard it rains, people still have to eat lunch, and the more it rains, the fewer of them want to go downstairs. Zhou Hai's phone hardly stopped. The system handed him four orders at once: three boxed lunches and one soup, going to four addresses in four different directions.

13 那份汤是送去医院的。备注上写着："家里老人住院，麻烦送到住院部三楼，谢谢。"汤装在一个塑料碗里，盖很薄。周海[†]把它放在保温箱[‡]最里面，又用三份盒饭把四周塞紧，免得路上一动就洒出来。有的路上积水已经到了小腿，汽车开过去，溅[§]起一人高的水。他只能放慢速度，可是屏幕上的数字不会因为下雨就停下来。

14 在一个路口转弯的时候，轮子压到了水下面的一个坑[¶]，车一滑，他整个人摔了出去。膝盖[*]重重地撞在地上，冷水一下子流进了雨衣里。他来不及管腿，爬起来第一件事就是打开保温箱：那碗汤一定完了。不料打开一看，汤碗稳稳地立在里面，一滴也没洒。倒是他自己的裤子破了一个洞，膝盖上又是血又是泥。他站在雨里，忍不住笑了一下：汤比人结实。

15 这一摔，后面两单肯定要晚了。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 保温箱 *bǎowēnxiāng* insulated delivery box
§ 溅 *jiàn* to splash
¶ 坑 *kēng* pothole
* 膝盖 *xīgài* knee

The soup was going to a hospital. The note said: "An elderly relative is in hospital. Please bring it to the third floor of the inpatient building. Thank you." The soup came in a plastic bowl with a thin lid. Zhou Hai put it at the very back of his box and packed the three lunches tight around it, so that it wouldn't slop out at the first jolt on the road. On some streets the water already came up to his shins, and passing cars threw up sprays as tall as a man. He had to slow down, but the number on the screen would not stop just because it was raining. 13

As he turned at a junction, his wheel hit a pothole hidden under the water; the scooter slid, and he was thrown off. His knee struck the ground hard, and cold water rushed into his raincoat. With no time to think about his leg, the first thing he did when he scrambled up was open the box: that soup must be done for. But when he opened it, to his surprise the bowl was standing there steadily, not a drop spilled. It was his own trousers that had a hole in them, and his knee was covered in blood and mud. Standing in the rain, he couldn't help laughing: the soup was tougher than he was. 14

After that fall, the next two orders were certain to be late. 15

15 他给顾客打电话道歉。第一个电话里是一个老大爷的声音：“不急不急，这么大的雨，你慢点儿骑，注意安全。”周海[†]拿着手机，半天没说出话来，最后连说了三个“谢谢”。第二个电话是一个年轻人接的：“怎么还没到？我午休一共才一个小时！”说完就挂了。周海并不怪他。这个城市里，好像每个人身上都有一个钟，在一秒一秒地走。

红灯[‡]

16 下午两点，周海停在一个很大的路口前。红灯上的数字是九十，手机上的数字是两分十秒。两个数字都在往下走，一个让他停，一个让他走。他旁边停着一个很年轻的骑手[§]，看样子不过二十岁，雨衣下面露出一张孩子一样的脸。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai

‡ 红灯 *hóngdēng* red light

§ 骑手 *qíshǒu* rider

He phoned the customers to apologise. The first call was answered by an old man: "No rush, no rush. In rain like this, ride slowly and stay safe." Zhou Hai held the phone and for a moment couldn't speak; in the end he said "thank you" three times. The second was answered by a young man: "Why isn't it here yet? I only get an hour for lunch!" And he hung up. Zhou Hai didn't really blame him. In this city, it seemed that everyone carried a clock somewhere on them, ticking away second by second. 15

Red Light

At two in the afternoon, Zhou Hai stopped at a big junction. The number on the red light said ninety; the number on his phone said two minutes ten. Both numbers were counting down; one told him to stop, the other told him to go. Beside him had stopped a very young rider who looked no more than twenty, a child's face showing under his raincoat hood. 16

16 年轻人低头看了看手机，又抬头看了看红灯[†]，脚已经放在了踏板上。

17 红灯还剩四十秒的时候，他冲了出去。他大概以为雨这么大，路上没什么车，不料一辆白色的小汽车正好从右边开了过来。刹车[‡]声、喇叭[§]声、雨声混在一起，年轻人连人带车倒在了路中间。周海[¶]的心一下子跳到了嗓子眼儿[*]。好在车开得不快，年轻人自己爬了起来，手上擦破了一大块皮。他站起来说的第一句话不是“好疼”，而是“我的餐呢？”

18 周海过去帮他把车扶起来，把散在地上的盒饭一个个捡回箱子里。开车的司机也下来了，又生气又害怕，问要不要去医院。年轻人一直摆手：“没事，没事，我还有三单呢。”他告诉周海，他才干了一个月，这个月已经超时了好几次，再超下去，钱就要被扣光了。

† 红灯 *hóngdēng* red light
‡ 刹车 *shāchē* to brake
§ 喇叭 *lǎba* horn
¶ 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
* 嗓子眼儿 *sǎngziyǎnr* throat (heart in mouth)

The young man looked down at his phone, then up at the light, his foot already on the footboard. 16

With forty seconds of red light left, he shot off. He must have thought that in rain this heavy there wouldn't be much traffic, but just then a small white car came from the right. The screech of brakes, the blare of a horn and the noise of the rain all ran together, and the young man went down in the middle of the road, scooter and all. Zhou Hai's heart leapt into his throat. Luckily the car hadn't been going fast, and the young man got up by himself, a big patch of skin scraped off his hand. The first thing he said when he stood up was not "that hurts" but "where's my food?" 17

Zhou Hai went over to help him lift the scooter up and picked the scattered lunch boxes off the ground one by one, back into the box. The driver got out too, angry and frightened at once, and asked if he needed to go to hospital. The young man kept waving his hand. "It's nothing, it's nothing. I've still got three orders." He told Zhou Hai that he had only been doing the job for a month, had already been late quite a few times this month, and if it went on his pay would be docked to nothing. 18

18 说完，他骑上车，一拐一拐地消失在雨里了。

19 这样的事，周海[†]不是第一次看见。2020年，网上有一篇写外卖骑手[‡]的长文章传开了，说骑手们被“困在系统里”：时间越给越少，很多人只好闯红灯、逆行[§]，用自己的安全去换那几分钟。那段时间，很多人都在讨论：是骑手太急，是顾客太急，还是那个算法[¶]太“聪明”？后来，有的平台在下单的页面上加了一个选择，顾客可以选“愿意多等几分钟”；有的平台说，要把一个死的时间改成一段时间，给骑手多留一点空间。据说第二年，有关部门也发了文件，要求平台不能用“最严”的算法来考核骑手。

20 也有人说，平台每天要送几千万份饭，既要快，又要便宜，还要安全，本来就不容易。很多骑手也喜欢这份工作的自由：不用看老板的脸色，多跑就多挣。周海说不清谁对谁错。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 骑手 *qíshǒu* rider
§ 逆行 *nìxíng* to ride against traffic
¶ 算法 *suànfǎ* algorithm

With that he got back on the scooter and wobbled off into the rain. 18

It was not the first time Zhou Hai had seen something like this. In 2020 19
a long article about delivery riders spread across the internet. It said riders were "trapped in the system": they were given less and less time, so many had no choice but to run red lights and ride against the traffic, trading their own safety for those few minutes. For a while, everyone seemed to be arguing about it: were the riders in too much of a hurry, were the customers, or was the algorithm too "clever"? Afterwards, some platforms added an option on the ordering page so customers could choose to "wait a few minutes longer"; others said they would replace a fixed deadline with a time window and leave riders a little more room. The following year, it is said, the authorities issued guidelines too, saying platforms must not judge riders by the "strictest" algorithm.

Others said that platforms deliver tens of millions of meals every day, and 20
making them fast, cheap and safe all at once was never going to be easy. Many riders liked the freedom of the job, too: no boss's face to watch, and the more you ride, the more you earn. Zhou Hai couldn't say who was right and who was wrong.

他只记得老马[1]的一句话：“按钮[2]是加了，可饿着肚子的人，有几个会去按呢？”

红灯[3]终于变绿了。周海[4]想起女儿在视频里一本正经[5]地教他：“爸爸，老师说，红灯停，绿灯[6]行。”他心里对自己说：宁可[7]晚两分钟，也要等灯，免得哪一天躺在路中间的是自己。这一单，他超时了三分钟。可是这一次，他一点儿也不后悔。

一个差评

下午五点，周海接到一单奶茶，送到一个新建的小区[8]。奶茶店里排着长队，他等了十五分钟才拿到。到了小区门口，门卫又不让他进了：“电动车不能进，这是规定。”

1 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Old Ma
2 按钮 *ànniǔ* button
3 红灯 *hóngdēng* red light
4 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
5 一本正经 *yīběn zhèngjīng* in all seriousness
6 绿灯 *lǜdēng* green light
7 宁可 *nìngkě* would rather
8 小区 *xiǎoqū* housing estate

He only remembered something Old Ma had said: "So they added a button. But how many hungry people are going to press it?" 20

At last the light turned green. Zhou Hai remembered his daughter on a video call, solemnly teaching him: "Dad, the teacher says stop at red, go at green." He told himself: better to be two minutes late and wait for the light, rather than one day be the one lying in the middle of the road. He was three minutes late with that order. But this time he didn't regret it in the least. 21

A Bad Review

At five in the afternoon, Zhou Hai got an order for bubble tea, to be taken to a newly built housing estate. There was a long queue at the tea shop, and it took him fifteen minutes to get the drinks. At the entrance, the gatekeeper stopped him as well: "No scooters inside. Those are the rules." 22

22 他要去的那座楼在小区[†]最后面，离大门有七八百米。他提着奶茶，拖着那条受伤的腿，在雨里一路小跑。敲门的时候，已经超时四分钟了。

23 开门的是一个中年男人，穿着拖鞋，屋里有孩子在哭。周海[‡]连忙说："对不起，来晚了，小区不让车进……"男人没等他说完，接过奶茶，关上了门。门里，孩子还在哭。十分钟以后，周海的手机上出现了一个差评："太慢，奶茶都不冰了。"

24 周海坐在车上，看着那一行字，心里不免有些难过。在他们那里，差评多了，等级就会下降，派到的好单就少，有时候还要扣钱。软件里有一个"申诉"的按钮[§]，下面最多能写一百个字。可是奶茶店的长队、门卫的规定、雨里的七八百米、还在流血的膝盖[¶]，一百个字怎么写得下？这一路上的事，本来就难以说清楚。

† 小区 *xiǎoqū* housing estate
‡ 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
§ 按钮 *ànniǔ* button
¶ 膝盖 *xīgài* knee

The building he needed was at the very back of the estate, seven or eight hun- 22
dred metres from the gate. Carrying the tea and dragging his injured leg, he jogged all the way through the rain. By the time he knocked on the door, he was four minutes late.

The door was opened by a middle-aged man in slippers; inside, a child was 23
crying. Zhou Hai hurried to say, "Sorry I'm late. The estate wouldn't let my scooter in..." Without waiting for him to finish, the man took the tea and shut the door. Behind it, the child was still crying. Ten minutes later a bad review appeared on Zhou Hai's phone: "Too slow. The tea wasn't even cold any more."

Zhou Hai sat on his scooter looking at that line of text, and couldn't help 24
feeling hurt. Where he worked, more bad reviews meant a lower grade, fewer good orders, and sometimes money taken out of his pay. In the app there was an "Appeal" button, and beneath it you could write at most a hundred characters. But the queue at the tea shop, the gatekeeper's rules, the seven or eight hundred metres in the rain, his still-bleeding knee: how could all that fit into a hundred characters? What had happened along the way was hard to explain in the first place.

他用湿手指打了一行：“商家出餐慢，小区[†]不让电动车进。”很快，系统自动回复了：“您的申诉已收到，我们将在三个工作日内处理。”

他给老马[‡]发了条消息，老马回了一段语音：“一个差评罢了，别往心里去。我刚干的时候，一天收过三个呢！”周海[§]听了，笑了一下。对那个男人来说，这不过是手指点一下罢了；对他来说，却可能是半天的饭钱。可他又想起门里那个一直在哭的孩子。也许那个男人今天也过得很糟糕，也许他也有一个停不下来的钟。

六点半，他在一座桥下躲雨，从口袋里拿出早上买的两个包子。包子早就凉了，他三口两口就吃完了，前后不到五分钟。妈妈打来电话，问他深圳[¶]是不是在下大雨。他说雨不大，今天跑得很顺利。摔倒和差评的事，他一个字也没提，免得老人晚上睡不着觉。

† 小区 *xiǎoqū* housing estate
‡ 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Old Ma
§ 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
¶ 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen

With wet fingers he typed one line: "The shop was slow with the order, and the estate didn't let scooters in." Soon the system replied automatically: "Your appeal has been received. We will deal with it within three working days." 24

He sent Old Ma a message, and Old Ma replied with a voice note: "It's just one bad review, that's all. Don't take it to heart. When I first started, I once got three in a day!" Zhou Hai listened and gave a little laugh. For that man it was nothing more than one tap of a finger; for Zhou Hai it might be half a day's food money. But then he remembered the child crying behind that door. Maybe that man had had a terrible day too; maybe he also had a clock that wouldn't stop. 25

At half past six he sheltered from the rain under a bridge and took out of his pocket the two steamed buns he had bought that morning. They had long gone cold; he wolfed them down in a few bites, in less than five minutes. His mother phoned to ask whether it was raining hard in Shenzhen. He said it wasn't raining much and today had gone very smoothly. About the fall and the bad review he didn't say a word, so that the old woman wouldn't lie awake that night. 26

十二楼的女孩

27 晚上十点二十，手机又响了。周海†一看地址，心里一动：阳光花园 7 号楼1202。还是那份最便宜的套餐，还是那句话：“麻烦快一点，谢谢！放门口就行。”他拿了餐，骑到楼下，却看见电梯门上贴着一张纸：“电梯维修，请走楼梯。”他看了看时间，还剩七分钟。他深吸了一口气，提着袋子开始往上爬。

28 楼道里的声控灯一层一层地亮起来，又一层一层地灭下去。到了七楼，膝盖‡开始一跳一跳地疼；到了十楼，他不得不扶着墙走。他一边爬，一边在心里算：再超时，今天就是第三次了。终于到了十二楼。他弯下腰，正要把袋子放在门口，不料门忽然开了。

29 门里站着一个二十多岁的女孩，还穿着上班的衣服，肩上背着电脑包，头发也是湿的。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai

‡ 膝盖 *xīgài* knee

The Girl on the Twelfth Floor

At twenty past ten that night, the phone rang again. Zhou Hai looked at 27
the address and stopped short: Sunshine Gardens, Building 7, Flat 1202. The same cheapest set meal, the same words: “Please hurry, thank you! Just leave it at the door.” He picked up the food and rode to the building, only to find a notice taped to the lift door: “Lift under repair. Please use the stairs.” He checked the time: seven minutes left. He took a deep breath and, bag in hand, began to climb.

The sound-activated lights in the stairwell came on floor by floor, and went 28
out again floor by floor. By the seventh floor his knee had begun to throb; by the tenth he had to lean on the wall as he went. As he climbed, he counted in his head: if he was late again, it would be the third time today. At last he reached the twelfth floor. He bent down and was about to set the bag by the door when, to his surprise, the door suddenly opened.

In the doorway stood a woman in her twenties, still in her work clothes, a 29
laptop bag on her shoulder, her hair wet too.

29 看样子，她也是刚到家。“我听见楼道里有脚步声，就想是不是你。”她看了看周海†湿透的衣服和破了的裤子，“电梯坏了，你是走上来的？你的腿怎么了？”“没事，下午摔了一下。”周海把袋子递给她，“您的饭，还热着。”

30 女孩接过袋子，却没有马上关门。她有点儿不好意思地说：“对不起，我每次都写‘快一点’，你一定觉得我很烦吧。”周海不知道说什么，只笑了笑。“其实我不是催‡你。”她说，“我每天十点多才下班，十一点还要开视频会，我们的客户在国外，那边正是白天。”“我写快一点，只是想开会前能吃上一口热饭，免得饿着肚子对着电脑。我只是饿罢了。”

31 周海忽然明白了。这个女孩身上，也有一个钟，只不过那个钟在别人手里。就跟他一样。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai

‡ 催 *cuī* to hurry (sb)

By the look of it, she had only just got home herself. "I heard footsteps on the stairs and wondered if it was you." She looked at Zhou Hai's soaked clothes and torn trousers. "The lift's broken. Did you walk up? What happened to your leg?" "It's nothing. I took a fall this afternoon." Zhou Hai handed her the bag. "Here's your food. It's still hot." 29

She took the bag but didn't close the door right away. A little embarrassed, she said, "I'm sorry. I always write 'please hurry'. You must think I'm a real pain." Zhou Hai didn't know what to say and just smiled. "Actually, I'm not trying to rush you," she said. "I don't finish work till after ten every day, and at eleven I still have a video meeting. Our clients are abroad, and it's daytime there." "When I write 'hurry', it's only because I want to get a mouthful of hot food before the meeting, so I'm not sitting in front of the computer on an empty stomach. I'm just hungry, that's all." 30

All at once Zhou Hai understood. This young woman carried a clock too; it was just that someone else held it. Just like him. 31

31 “你等一下。”女孩转身进了屋，很快拿出来一瓶热水和几张创可贴，“腿上的伤，先贴一下吧。”周海[†]想说不用，话到嘴边却变成了“谢谢”。

32 “对了，”女孩又说，“有一次，袋子上写着‘趁热吃[‡]’三个字，是你写的吗？”周海点了点头。那是他的习惯：晚上的单，他常常在袋子上写这三个字。小时候他放学回家晚，妈妈总是这样说。“那天我加班到半夜，看到那三个字，差点儿哭了。”女孩笑了，“以后我不写‘快一点’了。”门关上以前，周海知道了她姓林[§]，江西[¶]人，来深圳[*]三年了。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 趁热吃 *chènrè chī* eat it while it's hot
§ 林 *Lín* Lin (surname)
¶ 江西 *Jiāngxī* Jiangxi province
* 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen

"Wait a moment." She turned and went inside, and soon came back with a 31
bottle of hot water and a few plasters. "Put these on your leg for now." Zhou Hai meant to say there was no need, but when the words reached his lips they turned into "thank you."

"Oh, and," she added, "once the bag had 'Eat it hot' written on it. Was that 32
you?" Zhou Hai nodded. It was a habit of his: on late-night orders he often wrote those words on the bag. When he was little and came home late from school, his mother always said that to him. "I'd worked late till midnight that day, and when I saw those words I nearly cried." She smiled. "From now on I won't write 'please hurry'." Before the door closed, Zhou Hai learned that her surname was Lin, that she was from Jiangxi, and that she had been in Shenzhen for three years.

晚上十一点

33 下楼比上楼慢多了。周海[†]一只手扶着墙，一只手拿着那瓶热水，一层一层往下走。走到楼下，雨已经小了，只剩下细细的毛毛雨。他坐在电动车上，把创可贴一张一张贴在膝盖[‡]上。伤口不大，可是很疼。这时，手机又“叮[§]”了一声。

34 是一个新的单子：八公里，三十五分钟，因为下雨，还有补贴。要是在平时，他想都不想就会接。八公里，三十五分钟，雨天的夜路，要想准时，只能一路闯过去。他看着屏幕上那个一秒一秒变小的数字，又看了看手里那瓶还热着的水。过了一会儿，他按下了“下线”。那个数字不见了，屏幕一下子安静了下来。

35 他正要把手机放回口袋，屏幕又亮了。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 膝盖 *xīgài* knee
§ 叮 *dīng* ding (sound)

Eleven at Night

Going down took much longer than going up. With one hand on the wall and the other holding that bottle of hot water, Zhou Hai went down floor by floor. When he reached the bottom, the rain had eased, and only a fine drizzle was left. He sat on his scooter and stuck the plasters onto his knee one by one. The cut wasn't big, but it hurt a lot. Just then the phone went "ding" again. 33

It was a new order: eight kilometres, thirty-five minutes, and because of the rain, an extra allowance. On any other day he would have taken it without a second thought. Eight kilometres in thirty-five minutes, on wet roads at night: to make it on time he would have to charge through the whole way. He looked at the number on the screen shrinking second by second, and then at the bottle in his hand, still warm. After a while, he pressed "Go offline." The number vanished, and all at once the screen went quiet. 34

He was about to put the phone back in his pocket when the screen lit up again. 35

35 他以为是系统又派了单，不料是一条新的评价：五颗星。下面写着：“谢谢周师傅[†]，爬了十二层楼。不着急，注意安全。”周海把这几句话看了一遍又一遍。四年来，他收到过很多个好评[‡]，大多是系统自动给的，这是第一次有人叫出他的姓。

36 回去的路上，他骑得很慢。每一个红灯[§]，他都停下来等，看着灯上的数字从九十走到零。雨后的深圳[¶]很安静，高楼上还有很多窗户亮着灯。他想，那些窗户后面，也许还有很多个林[*]小姐，对着电脑，等着一碗热饭。这座城市这么大，大家都在赶时间，却很少有人停下来看一眼那个送时间的人。

37 回到出租屋，已经快十二点了。另外两个人已经睡了，老马[#]还坐在下铺看手机。他看了看周海的腿，什么也没问，起身给他煮了一碗面，还打了一个鸡蛋。“今天跑了多少单？”老马问。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 好评 *hǎopíng* good review
§ 红灯 *hóngdēng* red light
¶ 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
* 林 *Lín* Lin (surname)
\# 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Old Ma

He thought the system had sent him another order, but it turned out to be a new review: five stars. Beneath it was written: "Thank you, Master Zhou, for climbing twelve floors. No hurry. Stay safe." Zhou Hai read those few lines over and over. In four years he had received plenty of good reviews, most of them given automatically by the system; this was the first time anyone had called him by his name. 35

On the way back he rode slowly. At every red light he stopped and waited, watching the number on the light count from ninety down to zero. Shenzhen was quiet after the rain, and many windows in the tall buildings were still lit. Behind those windows, he thought, there were probably many more Miss Lins, facing their computers, waiting for a bowl of hot food. The city was so big, and everyone was racing the clock, yet hardly anyone stopped to take a look at the person who delivered their time. 36

It was nearly midnight when he got back to the rented room. The other two were already asleep; Old Ma was still sitting on his bottom bunk looking at his phone. He looked at Zhou Hai's leg, asked nothing, got up and cooked him a bowl of noodles, with an egg cracked in. "How many orders today?" Old Ma asked. 37

37 “比平时少。”周海[†]说，“等了很多红灯[‡]。”老马[§]笑了：“那就对了。”

38 周海给女儿发了一段语音：“小禾[¶]，爸爸今天听你的话了，红灯停，绿灯[*]行。”然后他坐在小桌子前，慢慢地吃那碗面，一次也没有看时间。在这座城市里，一碗面从厨房到饭桌上，大约需要三十分钟。而这一碗，他也吃了差不多三十分钟。明天早上六点，闹钟还会响。可是今天晚上，这三十分钟是他自己的。

† 周海 *Zhōu Hǎi* Zhou Hai
‡ 红灯 *hóngdēng* red light
§ 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Old Ma
¶ 小禾 *Xiǎohé* Xiaohe, Zhou Hai's daughter
* 绿灯 *lǜdēng* green light

"Fewer than usual," said Zhou Hai. "I waited at a lot of red lights." Old Ma 37
laughed. "Then you did it right."

Zhou Hai sent his daughter a voice message: "Xiaohe, Dad did what you 38
said today: stop at red, go at green." Then he sat at the little table and ate the noodles slowly, without looking at the time once. In this city, it takes about thirty minutes for a bowl of noodles to travel from a kitchen to a dining table. And this bowl, he took nearly thirty minutes to eat. At six tomorrow morning, the alarm would go off again. But tonight, these thirty minutes were his own.